The barefoot doctor who has caused a 1,000 healthy smiles

A rural 'doctor' initiative to tackle diabetes and blood pressure, where elementary testing and counsel is dispensed by barely literate people

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A medical degree is not the only thing that saves lives, and Ratna Srinivas, 48, an eighth standard dropout and the wife of an autodriver, proves that.

Thrice a week from 6 am she wears a white coat and sets off to the villages with a diabetes testing kit and a kit to measure BP. The minute she spots anything wrong, she advises people of dietary and lifestyle changes. The more serious cases are referred to either the nearest hospital or the organisation that trained her, Jnana Sanjeevini, under the Samathvam trust.

Ratna, or Ratnamma, as she is known in the villages she works in Ramanagaram district, has a niece with Type 1 diabetes. "I started empathising with people with diabetes when my sister's daughter was diagnosed with it. We never had any children and so I treated her like my own daughter. She was getting treated at the clinic and my heart went out to many people who suffered from the same disease."

The dire need for insulin just to keep the child alive opened Ratna's eyes to the seriousness of the problem, and also to the organisation which provides costly insulin for free to needy patients. Jnana Sanjeevini trained Ratna and volunteers like her -- who either have a child with Type 1 diabetes or parents/parents-in-law with the problem – to identify incidence of diabetes and BP in rural areas and to also spread awareness that help is available. The project is called Madhura Sanjeevini.

"I have several cases of children whose parents were on the verge of suicide, because they couldn't afford to keep the child alive. So we are training these barefoot doctors to spread awareness and identify patients quickly in the rural areas and ensure that we save lives," Dr S S Srikanta, Medical Director and Senior Consultant, Endocrinology-Diabetes, Samatvam Endocrinology Centre, told Bangalore Mirror.

There are 16 volunteers like Ratna, who have spread out into the villages around Bangalore. Ratna has not only screened over a 1,000 people in just the last four months, but is also doing follow-ups with patients, several of whom visit her thatched home in the hope of tasting her cooking also. The volunteers are allowed to charge a nominal sum for doing the tests, though the testing kits are provided to them for free. But Ratna does not charge for her services.

VANDANA KAMATH



Ratna Srinivas takes up this duty thrice a week. She starts her journey at 6 am

She has been attending regular classes for training at Jnana Sanjeevini every Sunday and also gives orientation programmes to many people who are willing to participate in community health affairs. "I generally finish all my work in the morning so that I can keep my afternoons free for this. It is my husband who is interested in this more than me. Before going to work he asks me which village I am going to screen today," she says.

Dr Srikanta said: "The basic requirement for any community health worker is the ability to read and write Kannada and numbers. Community health workers do not qualify as a quack as they only do the initial diagnosis and do not give treatment. This diagnosis can be done in any urban household. It is a pilot-based social initiative which has been undertaken for a period of two years. We have a free clinic every first Sunday for children and adults with diabetes."

BAREFOOT DOCTORS

The concept of barefoot doctors was largely instrumental in improving the community health in China, where farmers were given basic paramedical training to improve the life of thousands of people in rural areas. The term barefoot came to them because they used to go around treating people in the village barefoot.

Lost lectures, loos, labs...a loss lore

Commissioner of Collegiate Education paints a scary picture of college infrastructure in state

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Imagine a science college without a laboratory? Preposterous as it may sound, Commissioner for Collegiate Education BG Nanda Kumar has admitted that there is a shortage of 441 labs across 409 government colleges in the state. In fact, in these 409 government colleges, where 2.77 lakh students study, even basic infrastructure is lacking.

The shortage of classrooms is an estimated 2,280! Around 39 colleges don't have toilets, while 149 colleges don't have girls' waiting rooms. As if all this were not enough, some 236 colleges were without compound walls, 81 didn't have drinking water supply, 106 didn't have staff rooms, 313 didn't have auditoria, and 29 colleges didn't have library buildings! These details were made available during a recent meeting of the Education Department with the Lokayukta.

> **A proposal has been submitted to the government for a special grant of ₹630 crore for providing basic infrastructure**
>
> OFFICIAL, EDUCATION DEPARTMENT

Department officials said they require Rs 630 crore to provide the required infrastructure. "Building construction has been undertaken at 103 colleges. A proposal has been submitted to the government for a special grant of Rs 630 crore for providing basic infrastructure like classrooms, desks, and computers, etc.," said an official.

Faculty shortage too is affecting colleges badly. For instance, there is a shortage of 1,685 faculty members out of the total strength of 7,505. An additional 3,363 posts have to be created. Thus, the overall shortage goes up to 5,048. Adding to the urgency, fifty new colleges have opened this year and 130 more applications are pending for opening new colleges.



INQUIZITIVE

SUMIT DHAR

1 During the early 1920s, a number of New York drug addicts supported their drug habit by collecting scrap metal from industrial dumps and selling it elsewhere. **What nickname did they earn due to this act?**





2 In the late 1880s, the body of a beautiful young woman was pulled out of the Seine river in Paris. A pathologist at the Paris morgue was so taken by her beauty that he made a wax plaster cast death mask of her face. Much later, in 1958, Peter Safar and Asmund Laerdal modelled what they called Resusci Anne using the face of this lady. Their creation resulted in this face being called "the most kissed face" of all time. **Who is Resusci Anne?**

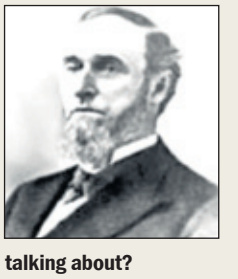
3 In 1976, when he visited the KFC franchise with New York Times restaurant critic Mimi Sheraton, he was not too pleased with the offerings. He unloaded on the chicken, calling it the "worst fried chicken I have seen" and the gravy, according to him, was "nothing more than wallpaper taste." **Who was it?**





4 William Chester Minor was an American army surgeon who settled in London. Suffering from paranoia, he fatally shot a man and was incarcerated at an asylum. During his incarceration, he heard about the call for volunteers for what was to become a seminal book. He devoted the rest of his life contributing to that book. **What book?**

5 The idea for this contraption came from Alfred P Southwick, a dentist in the state of York. Southwick developed this idea after he heard how quickly a drunk man died due to touching an exposed power cable. The first prototype was developed by Harold P Brown and Arthur Kennely, both employees of Thomas Edison. **What device are we talking about?**



ANSWERS

1. Since they collected junk, they were often called 'Junkies' and this name has stuck
2. Peter and Asmund modelled the face of the dummy used by doctors to practice CPR (Cardiopulmonary Resuscitation) on this lady
3. Colonel Sanders, the founder of KFC. This happened after he sold the franchise to a group of investors.
4. Oxford English Dictionary (OED)
5. Electric Chair



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